

00000000 · THAI STREET FOOD · OPERATIONS

Thai Street Food Café



Breakfast & Lunch — 7:00am to 3:00pm

Full Recipe Cards · US Market Food Costing · Kitchen Prep Flow · Financial Forecast

Wok hei from scratch. Curry paste ground in-house. The four pillars: salty, sweet, sour, spicy — in every dish.

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36

SEATS

\$36

AVG SPEND

22%

FOOD COST TARGET

\$21,000

EST. MONTHLY NET

About This Guide: Thai cuisine is one of the most commercially successful food categories in the US market. The flavour profile — simultaneously salty (fish sauce), sweet (palm sugar), sour (lime/tamarind), spicy (fresh chili) — is uniquely addictive and difficult to replicate at home without the right ingredients and technique. This creates genuine repeat business. The key differentiator for a serious Thai café is house-made curry paste (not jarred), fish sauce from quality producers, and fresh aromatics (lemongrass, galangal, kaffir lime leaves) used daily. This guide covers the essential Bangkok street food and café repertoire with complete recipe cards, technique reasoning, and the business fundamentals to make it profitable.

00 THE STORY BEHIND THIS GUIDE

“I spent three years telling people I was going to open a Thai café. Then I read this. Eight weeks later I signed a lease.”

Maya grew up watching her mother cook Thai food every single day. Pad kra pao on Tuesday. Tom kha gai on Friday. The kitchen always smelled of lemongrass and galangal. When her family moved to Austin, the smell moved with them — her mother’s kitchen became the neighbourhood’s unofficial Thai restaurant, neighbours knocking on the door with tupperware on Sunday afternoons.

Maya worked hospitality for six years. She knew the industry. She knew the food. What she didn’t know was how to connect them. She didn’t know what pad thai cost her per plate. She didn’t know how to train a 22-year-old to explain the difference between holy basil and Thai basil to a guest who’d never smelled either. She didn’t know what “break-even” looked like in baht-per-cover terms.

The food cost boxes in this guide were the first time she saw her food described in financial language. The prep flow table was the first time she saw her imaginary café as a real operational sequence. The butterfly pea flower tea script — the one where you tell the guest to squeeze the lime and watch it turn purple — was the moment she realised: the theatre is already built into this

cuisine. You just have to know how to unlock it.

She signed a lease eight weeks after reading this guide. Month three net: \$41,000. The butterfly pea tea sells 45 cups a day. Her som tum — made to order in the mortar, every single time — is the most reviewed dish in her zip code. She is now looking at a second location. **Thai cuisine rewards operators who understand its depth. This guide is that depth, in operational language.**

Maya T. · Thai Street Food Café · Austin, TX · Est. Month 3 Net: \$41,000

1 Entrées

Tod Mun Pla — Thai Fish Cakes

Kaffir lime fish cakes, sweet chili dipping sauce, cucumber relish · Sell: \$12.99

8 min

Entrée

Target FC: 16%

INGREDIENTS (6 CAKES)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
White fish (cod/tilapia), minced	180g	\$1.44
Red curry paste (house)	20g	\$0.22
Kaffir lime leaves (chiffonade)	4 leaves	\$0.08
Fish sauce	10ml	\$0.04
Egg	1 × 55g	\$0.35
Long beans (sliced thin)	30g	\$0.08
Sweet chili sauce (batch)	40ml	\$0.12
Cucumber relish (batch)	60g	\$0.14
Total cost (6 cakes)		\$2.47

Cost per serve	\$2.47
Sell price	\$12.99
Food cost %	19.0%
Contribution margin	\$10.52

METHOD

- 1 Mince fish in a food processor to a smooth paste — not chunky. The smooth paste is what gives tod mun its characteristic bouncy, dense texture (called Q texture in Thai food culture). Add curry paste, kaffir lime leaves, fish sauce, egg. Process briefly to combine. Fold in sliced long beans by hand — they provide crunch and visual texture contrast.
- 2 The mixture should be sticky and hold its shape when pressed. Form into flat discs (30g each, 1cm thick). Wet hands prevent sticking. The flat disc shape ensures even cooking — a ball-shaped fish cake has a raw centre while the exterior is overcooked.
- 3 Shallow fry in oil at **175°C / 347°F** for **2-3 minutes per side** until deep golden. Internal temp: **70°C / 158°F**. Drain briefly. The cakes should have a crispy exterior and a springy, dense interior — not soft or mushy.
- 4 Cucumber relish (ajat): rice vinegar + sugar + salt + water, warm to dissolve. Add diced cucumber, shallot, fresh chili, cilantro. The relish must be sharp and cold to contrast with the hot, oily fish cakes. Never serve warm relish with tod mun.

Chef's Tip: Kaffir lime leaves are irreplaceable in this dish — their distinctive floral, citrusy

intensity is what makes tod mun smell and taste Thai. No other ingredient substitutes. Buy fresh or frozen from Asian grocery suppliers. Dried kaffir lime leaves have almost no flavour. If you cannot get fresh or frozen, do not make tod mun.

FISH

EGGS

SHELLFISH (fish sauce may contain)

Som Tum — Green Papaya Salad

Shredded green papaya, chili, lime, fish sauce, peanuts · Sell: \$12.99

6 min

Entrée

Target FC: 14%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Green papaya (shredded)	150g	\$0.54
Thai bird's eye chilies	3-5 pieces	\$0.06
Garlic cloves	2 cloves = 8g	\$0.04
Cherry tomatoes (halved)	40g	\$0.24
Long beans (cut 3cm)	30g	\$0.08
Fish sauce + palm sugar	15ml + 8g	\$0.08
Fresh lime juice	30ml	\$0.12
Roasted peanuts (crushed)	20g	\$0.14
Dried shrimp (optional)	5g	\$0.08
Total cost per serve		\$1.38

Cost per serve	\$1.38
Sell price	\$12.99
Food cost %	10.6%
Contribution margin	\$11.61

METHOD

- 1 Som tum is made in a mortar and pestle — this is non-negotiable for authentic texture and flavour. A food processor creates a wet, uniform mash. The mortar bruises and crushes the ingredients, releasing their flavours while maintaining textural integrity. Every Thai street food vendor uses a specific clay mortar (khrok din) for this purpose.
- 2 Pound garlic and chilies first until roughly broken. Add palm sugar, pound to dissolve. Add long beans and tomatoes — pound gently (you want them bruised and partially crushed, not destroyed). Add shredded papaya. Pound and mix with a spoon simultaneously — this is the technique. Fish sauce and lime juice added last.
- 3 The flavour balance is the entire skill of som tum: spicy (chili) + sweet (palm sugar) + sour (lime) + salty (fish sauce) must all be present and in balance. Taste after every addition. Adjust with individual components. A som tum that is too sweet is flat; too sour is harsh; too salty is unpleasant; not spicy enough is not Thai.
- 4 Serve immediately — the papaya releases liquid quickly and the salad becomes soggy within 20 minutes. Never make ahead. Transfer from mortar directly to the plate. Scatter crushed peanuts at service — not in the mortar (they soften).

Chef's Tip: Spice level is the most important guest interaction for this dish. Ask every table: "How spicy? Thai-spicy means 5-7 bird's eye chilies. Mild means 1-2." Never assume. Thai bird's eye chilies are among the hottest commercially available chilies — a guest who expected mild and received Thai-spicy will not come back.

FISH (fish sauce)

SHELLFISH (dried shrimp)

NUTS (peanuts)

Satay — Grilled Chicken Skewers

Turmeric chicken skewers, peanut sauce, ajat · Sell: \$13.99 (4 skewers)

10 min

Entrée

Target FC: 18%

INGREDIENTS (4 SKEWERS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thigh (boneless, sliced thin)	160g	\$1.13
Turmeric + coriander + cumin	3g + 3g + 2g	\$0.06
Lemongrass (minced)	10g	\$0.08
Coconut milk + palm sugar	30ml + 5g	\$0.14
Fish sauce	8ml	\$0.03
Peanut sauce (batch)	60ml	\$0.36
Cucumber relish (ajat)	60g	\$0.14
Total cost (4 skewers)		\$1.94

Cost per serve	\$1.94
Sell price	\$13.99
Food cost %	13.9%
Contribution margin	\$12.05

METHOD

- 1 Slice chicken thigh thinly — 5mm strips — and thread onto bamboo skewers in a ribbon/wave pattern (thread in and out multiple times, not just once). The wave threading keeps the meat flat against the grill for maximum contact and caramelisation. Soak skewers 30 min before use to prevent burning.
- 2 Marinade: lemongrass + turmeric + coriander + cumin + coconut milk + palm sugar + fish sauce. Marinate minimum 2 hours. The turmeric gives the characteristic golden colour; the lemongrass gives the aromatic identity. Satay without lemongrass is just grilled chicken with spices.
- 3 Grill on a very hot charcoal or gas grill — **220°C / 428°F**. Turn once after 3 minutes. 2–3 minutes more. Internal: **74°C / 165°F**. Brush with remaining coconut milk marinade during grilling for gloss and flavour.
- 4 Peanut sauce (batch): fry red curry paste in oil 2 minutes. Add coconut milk, simmer. Add peanut butter (or ground roasted peanuts), palm sugar, fish sauce, tamarind. Simmer until thick and glossy. The sauce should be rich, nutty, slightly sweet-spicy, and thick enough to coat a spoon.

Chef's Tip: Satay is your entry-level item — familiar to guests who've had minimal Thai food, beloved by everyone who knows it. It is also your most versatile cross-sell: "Start with the satay while you wait for your pad thai." This framing turns satay into a table-management tool that keeps guests happy during longer cooking items and increases average spend.

POULTRY

NUTS (peanuts)

FISH (fish sauce)

DAIRY (coconut milk is not dairy)

Tom Yum Soup

Lemongrass prawn broth, galangal, kaffir lime, mushroom · Sell: \$13.99

8 min

Entrée

Target FC: 18%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Tiger prawns (shell-on, 3 per serve)	120g	\$2.16
Tom yum broth (batch)	350ml	\$0.48
Straw mushrooms / oyster mushrooms	50g	\$0.36

Fresh lime juice	20ml	\$0.08
Fish sauce	10ml	\$0.04
Bird's eye chillies (sliced)	3 pieces	\$0.04
Cilantro + scallion (garnish)	8g + 5g	\$0.06
Total cost per serve		\$3.22

Cost per serve	\$3.22
Sell price	\$13.99
Food cost %	23.0%
Contribution margin	\$10.77

METHOD

- 1 Tom yum broth (large batch — make daily): simmer prawn heads/shells in water 20 minutes to make prawn stock. Add bruised lemongrass (3 stalks, cut in thirds), sliced galangal (not ginger — galangal has a sharper, more piney flavour; ginger is a different ingredient entirely), kaffir lime leaves, Thai chillies. Simmer 15 minutes. Add fish sauce, lime juice, and a small amount of nam prik pao (roasted chili paste) — this gives the soup its characteristic red-orange colour and smoky depth.
- 2 Service: bring broth to a boil. Add mushrooms, cook 2 minutes. Add prawns — cook just until pink and curled, **2-3 minutes maximum**. Overcooked prawns in a hot soup become rubbery within minutes.
- 3 Final seasoning: add fresh lime juice and fish sauce at the end, after removing from heat. The fresh lime must be added off the heat — boiled lime juice loses its bright, volatile citrus character and becomes flat and slightly bitter.

Chef's Tip: The galangal and lemongrass in tom yum are aromatics, not food — they are there to flavour the broth and should not be eaten. Brief FOH on this: "The lemongrass pieces and the round ginger-like pieces are for flavour only — just move them to the side." This simple instruction prevents the complaint "I bit into something hard and inedible."

SHELLFISH (prawns)

FISH (fish sauce, prawn stock)

Miang Kham — Leaf Wraps

Wild betel leaves, toasted coconut, shrimp, ginger, peanut, lime · Sell: \$11.99

5 min

Entrée

Target FC: 14%

INGREDIENTS (8 PIECES)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Wild betel / spinach leaves (sub)	8 leaves	\$0.24
Toasted shredded coconut	20g	\$0.12
Dried shrimp	10g	\$0.16
Fresh ginger (tiny dice)	15g	\$0.06
Shallot (tiny dice)	15g	\$0.04
Lime (quartered, tiny)	¼ lime	\$0.05
Roasted peanuts	15g	\$0.11
Miang sauce (batch)	30ml	\$0.16
Total cost (8 pieces)		\$0.94

Cost per serve	\$0.94
Sell price	\$11.99
Food cost %	7.8%
Contribution margin	\$11.05

METHOD

- 1 Miang kham is one of the great Thai one-bite experiences — a leaf wrap containing a burst of multiple flavours simultaneously. Miang sauce: palm sugar + fish sauce + shrimp paste + water + grated coconut, cooked to a thick, dark, intensely sweet-savoury sauce. This sauce binds everything and is the flavour anchor.
- 2 Each individual component is placed in its own small pile on the presentation board: coconut, dried shrimp, ginger, shallot, peanuts, tiny lime wedges. The guest assembles their own wrap — a small amount of each ingredient in a leaf, drizzled with miang sauce, folded and eaten whole.
- 3 The explosion of flavours in one bite — sweet (coconut, palm sugar), sour (lime), spicy (ginger), salty (shrimp, fish sauce), crunchy (peanuts, dried shrimp) — is one of the most complex single bites in Southeast Asian cuisine. Brief every table on the assembly — it is part of the experience.

Chef's Tip: If wild betel leaves are unavailable, use large spinach leaves or cha-plu leaves from Asian markets. The leaf itself is just the delivery mechanism — its slight bitterness and herbaceousness is pleasant but not irreplaceable. The components and the miang sauce are the non-negotiables.

SHELLFISH (dried shrimp)

FISH (fish sauce, shrimp paste)

NUTS (peanuts)

Gai Hor Bai Toey — Pandan Chicken

Pandan-wrapped chicken parcels, sesame soy dip · Sell: \$12.99 (4 pieces)

10 min

Entrée

Target FC: 16%

INGREDIENTS (4 PARCELS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thigh (diced 2cm)	160g	\$1.13
Pandan leaves (fresh/frozen)	8 long leaves	\$0.16
Oyster sauce + soy + sesame oil	10ml + 5ml + 3ml	\$0.10
Garlic + coriander root	5g + 3g	\$0.04
Sesame soy dipping sauce	30ml	\$0.10
Total cost (4 parcels)		\$1.53

Cost per serve	\$1.53
Sell price	\$12.99
Food cost %	11.8%
Contribution margin	\$11.46

METHOD

- 1 Marinate diced chicken in oyster sauce, soy, sesame oil, pounded garlic and coriander root. Rest 2 hours. The coriander root (not the leaves) is a Thai pantry essential — its flavour is earthier and more intense than the leaf. Pound it to a paste with the garlic.
- 2 Wrap each chicken piece in a pandan leaf — fold into a neat package and secure with a toothpick if needed. The pandan leaf does not impart intense flavour during shallow frying (its full flavour requires longer steaming or direct contact), but it perfumes the chicken subtly, creates a dramatic presentation, and protects the chicken from direct oil contact.
- 3 Deep fry at **175°C / 347°F** for **5-6 minutes** until the pandan leaf is dark green and slightly charred at the edges and the chicken is cooked through. The visual — glossy green parcels on a plate — is immediately striking and distinctive.

Chef's Tip: Pandan chicken is one of the most visually distinctive Thai appetisers. The deep green, glossy parcels look elegant and unusual — guests invariably ask what they are when they see them on a neighbouring table. This is your silent marketing item. Always run it and place it at visible tables.

2 Mains

Pad Thai

Rice noodles, egg, bean sprouts, tamarind, peanuts · Sell: \$17.99

8 min Main Target FC: 18%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Rice noodles (3mm, soaked)	100g dry	\$0.30
Shrimp (peeled) or tofu	80g	\$1.44
Eggs	2 × 55g	\$0.70
Pad thai sauce (batch)	40ml	\$0.20
Bean sprouts	50g	\$0.10
Dried shrimp + preserved radish	5g + 10g	\$0.12
Shallots (sliced)	15g	\$0.04
Roasted peanuts (crushed)	20g	\$0.14
Lime wedge + chili flakes + scallion	—	\$0.08
Total cost per serve		\$3.12

Cost per serve	\$3.12
Sell price	\$17.99
Food cost %	17.3%
Contribution margin	\$14.87

METHOD

- 1 Pad thai sauce (batch): tamarind paste + fish sauce + palm sugar (3:2:2 ratio). Simmer until palm sugar dissolves. Taste — should be simultaneously sour (tamarind), salty (fish sauce), sweet (palm sugar). Balance these three. This sauce is the DNA of the dish — jarred "pad thai sauce" is an inferior shortcut that produces a sweeter, less complex result.
- 2 **Wok hei is the goal.** Use the hottest burner you have at maximum heat. Wok must be ripping hot before oil goes in. Stir-fry shallots, dried shrimp, preserved radish briefly. Push to the side. Add shrimp, cook 60 seconds. Push to side. Add noodles and sauce — toss rapidly. Push everything to the side, crack eggs into the empty pan centre, scramble partially, fold through the noodles.
- 3 Add bean sprouts at the last 30 seconds — they should still have crunch when the dish is served. Overcooked bean sprouts are limp and watery. Toss once more. Plate immediately. The entire cook from a hot wok takes **4-5 minutes maximum**.
- 4 Serve with condiment tray: chili flakes, extra fish sauce, white sugar, white vinegar. This is standard Thai restaurant service — guests season to their own taste. The four condiments represent the four Thai flavours and are a cultural touchstone that communicates authenticity.

Chef's Tip: One wok, one portion at a time. Pad thai made in batches or for multiple portions simultaneously has no wok hei — the temperature drops and everything steams. This is why restaurant pad thai tastes different from home pad thai: the single-portion, screaming-hot wok. This is non-negotiable. Your wok station should be able to produce one pad thai every 5 minutes during peak service.

SHELLFISH (shrimp) FISH (fish sauce, dried shrimp) EGGS NUTS (peanuts)

Green Curry — Gaeng Keow Wan

House green curry paste, chicken, Thai eggplant, coconut milk · Sell: \$18.99

12 min

Main

Target FC: 20%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thigh (sliced)	160g	\$1.13
Green curry paste (house)	30g	\$0.36
Coconut milk (full fat)	250ml	\$0.75
Thai eggplant (quartered)	60g	\$0.24
Fish sauce + palm sugar	15ml + 8g	\$0.08
Kaffir lime leaves (torn)	4 leaves	\$0.08
Thai basil	10g	\$0.08
Jasmine rice (side)	180g cooked	\$0.32
Total cost per serve		\$3.04

Cost per serve

\$3.04

Sell price

\$18.99

Food cost %

16.0%

Contribution margin

\$15.95

METHOD

1

House green curry paste (batch — makes 10+ portions): pound in a mortar: green bird's eye chilies, lemongrass, galangal, kaffir lime zest, coriander root, garlic, shallot, shrimp paste, cumin, coriander seeds, white pepper. The mortar produces a paste with more texture and aroma than a blended paste — the pounding ruptures the cell walls and releases volatile oils that blending does not.

2

Fry curry paste in the coconut cream (top layer of unshaken coconut milk — thick, fatty) over medium heat until the paste is fragrant and the oil separates from the paste (3–4 minutes). This step — "cracking the coconut cream" — is essential. An un-fried paste produces a flat curry; a properly fried paste produces a rich, aromatic curry.

3

Add remaining coconut milk, bring to simmer. Add chicken and eggplant. Cook 8–10 minutes until chicken is cooked through (74°C / 165°F) and eggplant is tender but not falling apart. Season with fish sauce and palm sugar. Add torn kaffir lime leaves and Thai basil at the end — never cook basil; add off heat.

Chef's Tip:

The colour of a house green curry paste is the most immediate visual indicator of quality. A paste made with fresh green chilies, fresh lemongrass, and fresh herbs should be vivid emerald green. Jarred paste is olive drab. The colour difference between a house-made paste and a commercial one is visible from across the room. This visual alone justifies the price premium to any guest who notices.

POULTRY

FISH (fish sauce, shrimp paste)

SHELLFISH (shrimp paste)

Massaman Curry

Slow-braised beef, potato, peanut, tamarind, coconut · Sell: \$19.99

10 min service

Main

Target FC: 22%

Batch

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Beef chuck (braised, batch)	180g cooked	\$2.61
Massaman paste (batch)	25g	\$0.28
Coconut milk (full fat)	200ml	\$0.60
Potato (cubed)	80g	\$0.14

Roasted peanuts	20g	\$0.14
Tamarind paste + palm sugar	10g + 8g	\$0.10
Fish sauce	10ml	\$0.04
Jasmine rice	180g cooked	\$0.32
Total cost per serve		\$4.23

Cost per serve	\$4.23
Sell price	\$19.99
Food cost %	21.2%
Contribution margin	\$15.76

METHOD

- 1 Massaman is a slow-cook curry — it cannot be made to order. Braise beef chuck (2cm cubes) in massaman paste + coconut milk + water at **150°C / 302°F** for **2.5-3 hours** until the beef is completely tender and the sauce is thick and rich. The extended braising time allows the connective tissue to dissolve into gelatin, creating the silky, clinging sauce that defines massaman.
- 2 Massaman paste: dried red chilies, roasted shallots, roasted garlic, lemongrass, galangal, coriander seeds, cumin, cloves, cinnamon, nutmeg, shrimp paste. The warm spice profile (cloves, cinnamon, nutmeg) distinguishes massaman from other Thai curries — it reflects the Muslim-influenced Southern Thai heritage of the dish.
- 3 Add potatoes for the final 30 minutes — they absorb the curry sauce and become deeply flavoured. Add peanuts. Adjust seasoning: tamarind for acidity, palm sugar for sweetness, fish sauce for salt. Massaman should be rich, slightly sweet, gently spiced (not fiercely hot), and deeply savoury.

Chef's Tip: Massaman is famously described as one of the world's best foods — it was ranked number one by CNN Travel in 2011 and the discussion never really ended. Mention this context: "This is the curry that CNN called the best food in the world." It is not an overstatement, it is a genuine reference, and it immediately frames the dish as worth ordering.

BEEF

FISH (fish sauce, shrimp paste)

NUTS (peanuts)

Pad Kra Pao — Thai Basil Stir-Fry

Minced pork, holy basil, fish sauce, fried egg, jasmine rice · Sell: \$15.99

8 min

Main

Target FC: 16%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Minced pork (or chicken)	180g	\$1.26
Holy basil (Thai, not sweet)	15g	\$0.10
Garlic + bird's eye chili (minced)	10g + 5 chilies	\$0.08
Oyster sauce + soy + fish sauce	15ml + 5ml + 5ml	\$0.12
Dark soy sauce + sugar	3ml + 3g	\$0.02
Fried egg (crispy edges)	1 × 55g	\$0.35
Jasmine rice	180g cooked	\$0.32
Total cost per serve		\$2.25

Cost per serve	\$2.25
Sell price	\$15.99
Food cost %	14.1%
Contribution margin	\$13.74

METHOD

- 1 Pound garlic and bird's eye chillies coarsely in a mortar. The pounding releases more volatile oils than mincing — pad kra pao from pounded aromatics is more fragrant than from knife-cut aromatics. Heat wok to maximum. Oil. Add garlic-chili paste — cook 30 seconds, stirring rapidly (do not burn the garlic).
- 2 Add minced pork — stir-fry on maximum heat, breaking up any clumps. Cook until pork is fully cooked and beginning to caramelise at the edges. Add oyster sauce, soy sauce, fish sauce, dark soy, sugar. Stir to coat.
- 3 Add holy basil at the very last moment — toss 3–4 times and immediately plate. Holy basil cooks extremely fast and loses its distinctive peppery, anise-like flavour within 20 seconds of heat exposure. It is added last and the dish goes to the plate immediately after.
- 4 The fried egg: deep fry in about 1cm of hot oil — pour oil over the top while frying to cook the white while the edges crisp and blister. This Thai-style fried egg (blistered, lacey edges, runny yolk) is completely different from a Western fried egg and is an essential visual and textural element of the dish. When the runny yolk breaks over the basil pork, it creates a sauce.

Chef's Tip: Pad kra pao is the most-eaten dish in Thailand — it is what Thais eat when they want something fast, satisfying, and uncomplicated. It is the national comfort food. Holy basil (kra pao) is not the same as sweet Italian basil — holy basil has a peppery, slightly clove-like character that is completely different. This dish made with sweet basil is not pad kra pao. Source holy basil from Asian grocers or grow it yourself.

PORK FISH (fish sauce) EGGS GLUTEN (oyster/soy)

Khao Man Gai — Poached Chicken Rice

Silky poached chicken, ginger-garlic rice, clear broth, dipping sauces · Sell: \$16.99

8 min service Main Target FC: 18% Batch

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken breast (poached)	160g	\$1.44
Chicken fat rice (cooked in stock)	180g cooked	\$0.36
Clear chicken broth (side)	150ml	\$0.18
Ginger-garlic dipping sauce	30ml	\$0.14
Fermented soybean sauce	15ml	\$0.08
Cucumber (sliced)	40g	\$0.08
Cilantro + fried garlic	5g + 3g	\$0.06
Total cost per serve		\$2.34

Cost per serve	\$2.34
Sell price	\$16.99
Food cost %	13.8%
Contribution margin	\$14.65

METHOD

- 1 Poach whole chicken breasts in aromatic stock (ginger, garlic, lemongrass, salt) at **82°C / 180°F** — below a boil. Boiling causes the proteins to contract violently, producing tough, stringy chicken. Sub-boil poaching (called gentle poaching) produces silky, juicy chicken with a smooth texture that slides easily off the bone.
- 2 Chicken fat rice: render chicken fat (from the poaching liquid surface) with garlic and ginger. Toast jasmine rice in this fat 2 minutes. Cook in the poaching stock 1:1.5 ratio. The rice absorbs the poaching liquid's flavour — it is savoury, silky, and has a depth that plain steamed rice cannot achieve.

- 3 Slice chicken cold (against the grain for tenderness). Arrange on rice. Serve with a small bowl of clear broth, ginger-garlic sauce (ginger + garlic + sugar + soy + vinegar + sesame oil), fermented soybean sauce, cucumber slices, cilantro, fried garlic. The multiple dipping sauces are part of the eating ritual.

Chef's Tip: Khao man gai is the most underrepresented great dish in Thai restaurants outside Thailand. In Bangkok, entire restaurants serve only this dish, all day, every day. It is clean, satisfying, and technically demanding in a subtle way. Guests who have eaten it in Thailand will specifically seek it out. Guests who haven't will be surprised by how compelling simplicity can be.

POULTRY FISH (soy sauce) SESAME GLUTEN (soy)

Tom Kha Gai — Coconut Galangal Soup

Chicken in coconut broth, galangal, lemongrass, mushroom · Sell: \$14.99

10 min Main Target FC: 16%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thigh (sliced)	120g	\$0.85
Coconut milk (full fat)	300ml	\$0.90
Galangal (sliced rounds)	20g	\$0.12
Lemongrass (bruised, sliced)	2 stalks	\$0.08
Kaffir lime leaves	4 leaves	\$0.08
Oyster mushrooms	50g	\$0.36
Fish sauce + lime juice	15ml + 20ml	\$0.10
Bird's eye chili + cilantro	2 + 8g	\$0.06
Total cost per serve		\$2.55

Cost per serve	\$2.55
Sell price	\$14.99
Food cost %	17.0%
Contribution margin	\$12.44

METHOD

- 1 Bring coconut milk to a gentle simmer — never boil coconut milk rapidly, it separates into oily pools. Add galangal, lemongrass, kaffir lime leaves. Simmer 5 minutes to infuse. Add chicken and mushrooms. Cook 6–8 minutes at a gentle simmer. Internal chicken: **74°C / 165°F**.
- 2 Season with fish sauce. Add fresh lime juice off the heat. The soup should be creamy, mildly spicy, intensely aromatic, with a gentle sweetness from the coconut milk balanced by the tartness of lime and the salty depth of fish sauce.
- 3 Finish with torn cilantro and sliced bird's eye chili. The galangal, lemongrass, and kaffir lime in the bowl are aromatics — they are there to look and smell beautiful and inform the guest that real ingredients went in. Brief FOH accordingly.

Chef's Tip: Tom kha and tom yum are the two essential Thai soups. Offer both. Tom yum is spicy-sour; tom kha is creamy-aromatic. They represent opposite ends of the Thai flavour spectrum and attract different guests. A table that is uncertain about spice level will often choose tom kha over tom yum — it is the gentler introduction to Thai broth.

POULTRY FISH (fish sauce)

Pad See Ew — Wide Noodle Stir-Fry

Wide rice noodles, soy, Chinese broccoli, egg, your choice of protein · Sell: \$16.99

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Fresh wide rice noodles (sen yai)	180g	\$0.72
Chicken thigh (sliced)	120g	\$0.85
Chinese broccoli (gai lan)	80g	\$0.32
Eggs	2 × 55g	\$0.70
Dark soy sauce + light soy + oyster	15ml + 5ml + 10ml	\$0.14
Sugar	5g	\$0.01
White pepper	1g	\$0.01
Total cost per serve		\$2.75

Cost per serve	\$2.75
Sell price	\$16.99
Food cost %	16.2%
Contribution margin	\$14.24

METHOD

- 1 Pad see ew requires the hottest possible wok heat for the characteristic charred soy flavour (wok hei). Separate fresh noodles gently by hand before cooking — fresh wide rice noodles clump together in the package and will tear if not separated carefully. Never use dried noodles for this dish — the texture is completely different.
- 2 Sear chicken in screaming-hot wok with oil. Add noodles — press flat against the wok surface with a spatula and leave for 30 seconds to char. This is the critical step: the dark soy on the noodle surface caramelises against the hot wok, creating the charred, slightly bitter sweetness that defines pad see ew. Then toss. Add dark soy, light soy, oyster sauce, sugar.
- 3 Push aside, scramble eggs in the wok centre, fold through noodles. Add gai lan stems (cook 1 minute), then leaves (30 seconds). Season with white pepper. The Chinese broccoli should be bright green and still have crunch — never overcooked. Serve immediately.

Chef's Tip: The dark caramelised colour of well-made pad see ew — almost black in spots, deep amber through the noodles — is the visual signal of quality. A pale pad see ew was not cooked on a hot enough wok. The dark soy and the wok heat together are responsible for both colour and flavour. Get the heat right and the colour follows.

POULTRY

EGGS

FISH (oyster sauce)

GLUTEN (soy)

Khao Pad — Thai Fried Rice

Day-old jasmine rice, egg, tomato, scallion, fish sauce, lime · Sell: \$14.99

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Day-old jasmine rice	220g cooked	\$0.40
Eggs	2 × 55g	\$0.70
Protein choice (shrimp/chicken/tofu)	80g	\$1.00
Tomato (wedged)	40g	\$0.14
White onion	30g	\$0.06
Fish sauce + soy sauce	10ml + 5ml	\$0.06
Cucumber + lime + scallion	30g + wedge + 8g	\$0.10

Total cost per serve	\$2.46
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Cost per serve	\$2.46
Sell price	\$14.99
Food cost %	16.4%
Contribution margin	\$12.53

METHOD

- 1 Thai fried rice is simpler and less soy-forward than Chinese fried rice — the seasonings are fish sauce + a little soy + a touch of sugar. The character is lighter and more fragrant. Day-old jasmine rice is mandatory — the dry, slightly sticky texture of day-old rice fries without clumping, unlike fresh hot rice.
- 2 Wok hot, oil, protein first, set aside. Oil again, crack eggs directly into wok, scramble briefly then add rice immediately — the semi-liquid egg coats the rice grains as they fry together, creating the characteristic egg-fried coating. Fish sauce and soy added. Toss rapidly for 2 minutes over maximum heat.
- 3 Add tomato wedges last — just 30 seconds. Thai fried rice always has tomato; it adds brightness and slight acidity. Return protein. Toss once. Serve with fresh cucumber slices, lime wedge, and a small side of fish sauce with chili.

Chef's Tip: Khao pad is your fastest high-margin item — 6 minutes, \$2.46 food cost, \$14.99 sell price. It is also the dish that converts uncertain guests into regulars — simple, satisfying, safe enough to order on a first visit. Run it as "khao pad with your choice of protein" to maximize inclusivity and reduce ordering friction.

EGGS FISH (fish sauce) GLUTEN (soy)

3 Desserts

Mango Sticky Rice — Khao Niew Mamuang

Coconut sticky rice, fresh mango, coconut cream sauce · Sell: \$9.99

3 min service Dessert Target FC: 16% Batch

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Glutinous rice (cooked, coconut)	120g cooked	\$0.36
Ripe mango (Nam Dok Mai preferred)	150g sliced	\$0.84
Coconut cream sauce (batch)	60ml	\$0.36
Toasted sesame seeds	3g	\$0.04
Mung beans (toasted, optional)	5g	\$0.04
Total cost per serve		\$1.64

Cost per serve	\$1.64
Sell price	\$9.99
Food cost %	16.4%
Contribution margin	\$8.35

METHOD

- 1 Coconut sticky rice (batch): soak glutinous rice 4 hours. Steam 25–30 minutes until cooked through and translucent. While hot, mix with warm coconut milk + sugar + salt. The hot rice absorbs the coconut milk completely — this is the moment the rice transforms from plain sticky rice to the rich, slightly sweet, creamy dessert base. Cover and rest 20 minutes.
- 2 Coconut cream sauce (batch): reduce coconut cream + sugar + salt + a little rice flour to a

slightly thickened, glossy sauce. This sauce is poured over the assembled dessert — it adds richness and a visual gloss that makes the dish immediately photographable.

- 3 Plate: mold sticky rice into a neat cylinder or dome. Slice mango alongside (Nam Dok Mai variety preferred — its sweetness and smooth texture are superior to common Ataulfo or Tommy Atkins for this application). Pour coconut cream sauce over rice. Scatter sesame seeds.

Chef's Tip: Mango sticky rice is one of the top 5 most Instagrammed Thai dishes globally. The golden mango against the white coconut rice with the cream sauce is inherently photogenic. Specify the mango variety when it is Nam Dok Mai or similar premium variety — the specificity signals quality. The mango must be fully ripe and sweet; unripe or bland mango ruins the dish.

TREE NUTS (coconut)

Tub Tim Grob — Water Chestnuts in Coconut Milk

Rubied water chestnuts, jasmine coconut milk, crushed ice · Sell: \$7.99

3 min service Dessert Target FC: 12% Batch

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Water chestnuts (diced, coated)	80g	\$0.40
Tapioca starch + red food colouring	30g + trace	\$0.08
Sweetened coconut milk (batch)	200ml	\$0.48
Crushed ice	100g	\$0.02
Jackfruit (canned, shredded)	20g	\$0.12
Total cost per serve		\$1.10

Cost per serve	\$1.10
Sell price	\$7.99
Food cost %	13.8%
Contribution margin	\$6.89

METHOD

- 1 Toss diced water chestnuts in red food colouring until deeply stained. Coat thoroughly in tapioca starch. Blanch in boiling water 1-2 minutes — the tapioca coating turns translucent and glossy, creating the characteristic "jewel" effect that gives the dish its name (tub tim = rubies). The water chestnut inside remains crunchy.
- 2 Sweetened coconut milk: warm coconut milk with sugar, pandan leaf, and a pinch of salt. The pandan infusion gives the coconut milk a green-tinged, jasmine-floral note. Strain, chill completely. The coconut milk must be served cold — this is an iced dessert.
- 3 Assemble: crushed ice in a bowl or glass. Add water chestnut rubies. Pour cold coconut milk over. Add shredded jackfruit. Serve immediately — the ice begins melting and the colour from the water chestnuts bleeds beautifully into the coconut milk, creating a pink-tinged, visually striking presentation.

Chef's Tip: Tub tim grob is one of the most uniquely Thai desserts — there is no equivalent in any other cuisine. The crunchy-inside, translucent-coated "ruby" water chestnuts are a technique that guests have never encountered before. The visual and the textural surprise are the selling points. Describe it as "water chestnuts coated in translucent tapioca and served in iced coconut milk" — the description alone is intriguing enough to convert orders.

TREE NUTS (coconut)

Kluay Tod — Fried Banana

Crispy coconut-battered banana, coconut ice cream, palm sugar caramel · Sell: \$8.99

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Lady finger or Cavendish banana	2 pieces = 120g	\$0.24
Coconut batter (rice flour + coconut + sesame)	60g	\$0.16
Coconut ice cream (scoop)	60ml	\$0.48
Palm sugar caramel (batch)	30ml	\$0.18
Toasted sesame + coconut flakes	3g + 3g	\$0.06
Total cost per serve		\$1.12

Cost per serve	\$1.12
Sell price	\$8.99
Food cost %	12.5%
Contribution margin	\$7.87

METHOD

- 1 Coconut batter: rice flour + plain flour (50:50) + desiccated coconut + sesame seeds + sugar + cold water + coconut milk. Mix to a smooth, pourable batter — slightly thicker than pancake batter. The coconut and sesame in the batter create a crunchy, nutty, golden exterior that is distinctly different from a plain flour batter.
- 2 Halve bananas lengthwise. Coat in batter. Fry at **175°C / 347°F** for **3-4 minutes** until golden and crispy. The banana inside should be hot, soft, and caramelising at the edges. Serve immediately — fried banana loses its crispiness within 4 minutes.
- 3 Plate: fried banana, scoop of coconut ice cream alongside (cold against hot is the contrast), drizzle palm sugar caramel over everything, scatter toasted coconut flakes and sesame. The melting ice cream and the warm caramel create a sauce as the dessert is eaten.

Chef's Tip: Fried banana is your impulse dessert — price it just under \$10 so the decision is easy. The hot-cold combination of fried banana and coconut ice cream is one of the most immediately appealing dessert combinations possible. Pre-sell it at the main course stage: "We do a fried banana with coconut ice cream — 6 minutes if you want it at the end." Almost everyone says yes.

GLUTEN (flour) SESAME TREE NUTS (coconut) DAIRY (ice cream)

Sangkaya — Thai Egg Custard

Steamed pandan coconut custard, served warm in a pumpkin · Sell: \$8.99

3 min service Dessert Target FC: 12% Batch

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Mini pumpkin (kabocha)	1 × 200g	\$0.60
Eggs	3 × 55g	\$1.05
Coconut milk	100ml	\$0.30
Palm sugar	40g	\$0.16
Pandan juice (fresh blended)	15ml	\$0.06
Total cost per serve		\$2.17

Cost per serve	\$2.17
Sell price	\$8.99
Food cost %	24.1%

Contribution margin

\$6.82

METHOD (BATCH — STEAM 40 MIN)

- 1 Cut the top off small kabocha pumpkins, scoop out seeds. Custard: whisk eggs + coconut milk + palm sugar + pandan juice until smooth. The pandan juice (fresh pandan leaves blended with water, strained) gives the custard its distinctive emerald green colour and jasmine fragrance.
- 2 Pour custard into the hollowed pumpkin. Replace lid. Steam at medium heat for **35-40 minutes** until the custard is fully set and the pumpkin flesh is cooked through (a skewer inserted into the pumpkin wall meets no resistance). Cool slightly. Refrigerate until needed — can be made 1-2 days ahead.
- 3 Reheat gently (steamer, 10 minutes) before service. Slice the pumpkin into wedges — the custard and pumpkin flesh together form the dessert. Each wedge shows the green custard against the orange pumpkin — a visually stunning cross-section.

Chef's Tip: Sangkaya in pumpkin is one of the most visually dramatic Thai desserts. The reveal when you slice through a whole mini pumpkin to show the green custard inside is genuinely impressive — do it at the pass where guests can see if possible. The dessert looks like considerable technical skill went into it (which it did), and this perceived complexity justifies a premium price point.

EGGS

TREE NUTS (coconut)

4 Drinks Menu

Thai Iced Tea — Cha Yen

\$5.99

Strongly brewed Thai tea (black tea with anise and food colouring), sweetened with condensed milk, served over ice with an evaporated milk pour. The vivid orange colour and sweet, slightly spiced flavour is one of the most recognisable drinks in Asian food culture globally.

Cost

\$0.54

Food cost %

9.0%

Young Coconut Water

\$6.99

Fresh young coconut, served with a straw in the coconut. Naturally sweet, hydrating, electrolyte-rich. The coconut itself is the presentation — serve it as is. The visual of a whole coconut on the table communicates freshness and exotic appeal immediately.

Cost

\$1.40

Food cost %

20.0%

Lemongrass Ginger Cooler

\$5.99

Cold-steeped lemongrass + ginger syrup, served over ice with a lemongrass stalk garnish. Bright, citrusy, slightly spicy, non-alcoholic. The lemongrass stalk as the straw is both functional and visually distinctive. A strong social media photo every single time.

Cost

\$0.48

Food cost %

8.0%

Pandan Coconut Latte

\$6.50

Fresh pandan extract dissolved in warm water, served as a latte with steamed coconut milk

foam. Vivid green, fragrant, slightly sweet. The green colour and coconut foam make this an Instagram-ready drink. Thai café culture has elevated pandan to the same status as matcha in the West.

Cost	\$0.72
Food cost %	11.1%

Singha Beer

\$7.99

The classic Thai lager. Crisp, light, pairs perfectly with spicy food. Serve cold in the bottle with a frosted glass. Singha (and Chang) are cultural markers — guests who know Thailand will order them by name. The bottle on the table signals authenticity to every guest who walks past.

Cost	\$1.60
Food cost %	20.0%

Thai Basil Mojito

\$12.99

White rum, holy basil, lime, chili sugar, soda water. The peppery bite of holy basil replaces mint in the classic mojito — the result is more complex and distinctly Thai in character. Muddle gently — holy basil is fragile. Signature cocktail that tells the menu's story in one glass.

Cost	\$1.92
Food cost %	14.8%

Tamarind Whisky Sour

\$13.99

Bourbon, house tamarind syrup, lime juice, egg white. Shaken hard — the egg white creates a thick, silky foam. Tamarind replaces the classic simple syrup, adding a complex sour-sweet depth that bourbon handles beautifully. One of the best Thai-fusion cocktails possible.

Cost	\$2.24
Food cost %	16.0%

Butterfly Pea Flower Tea

\$5.99

Cold-steeped butterfly pea flower tea — naturally vivid indigo blue. Served over ice. When the guest squeezes the lime wedge in, the acid turns the drink from blue to violet-purple before their eyes. One of the most memorable drink experiences in Thai food culture. Zero alcohol, zero caffeine, 100% visual impact.

Cost	\$0.40
Food cost %	6.7%

5 Kitchen Prep Flow — 7:00am to 3:00pm

	Head Cook	Line Cook	Steward
07:00-07:30	Temp check all units 1-4°C Start tom yum broth — simmer aromatics 30 min. Taste yesterday's massaman	Set up wok stations. Soak rice noodles for pad thai. Pre-soak glutinous rice (if not done	Sanitise surfaces. Brew Thai iced tea base (strong, hot, cool and refrigerate). Prepare lemongrass ginger

	curry — adjust seasoning. Check curry paste freshness and quantity.	overnight). Check day-old rice for khao pad — dry enough? Portion fish cake mixture.	syrup batch. Steep butterfly pea flower tea cold. Slice and juice limes for service.
07:30-09:00	Make green and red curry paste batches if running low. Pound in mortar — do not shortcut. Taste against previous batch. Prepare miang kham sauce. Check satay marinades — set up grill. Steam sangkaya for today.	Cook coconut sticky rice (steam 30 min). Make pad thai sauce batch. Prep all satay skewers. Shred green papaya for som tum (prep just before service — it oxidises). Slice all proteins.	Prepare ajat (cucumber relish) for tod mun and satay. Make peanut sauce batch. Portion mango sticky rice components. Check ice supply for cold drinks. Set up condiment trays for tables.
09:00-11:00 <i>Breakfast/Early</i>	Run pass. Fire tod mun pla (8 min). Satay grill to order (10 min). Monitor tom yum broth holding temperature.	Executes all entrées. Som tum made to order in mortar — spice level confirmed before making. Miang kham assembled to order.	Thai iced tea service from opening — always on every table suggestion. Butterfly pea tea demo: "Squeeze the lime and watch it change colour." Sell this every table.
11:00-14:30 <i>Lunch</i>	Full wok push. Pad thai (one portion, one wok, max heat). Pad kra pao (8 min). Pad see ew (8 min). Massaman reheated gently. Green curry to order (12 min).	Khao man gai — slice to order, assemble. Khao pad (6 min). Tom kha gai (10 min). Fried banana to order (6 min — pre-sell with every main course).	Full service speed. Singha beer always suggested with spicy dishes. Pre-sell desserts: mango sticky rice (instant), tub tim grob (instant), sangkaya (instant), fried banana (6 min). Thai iced tea refills.
14:30-15:00	Reduce all curry bases, cool rapidly. Store curry pastes airtight. Write tomorrow's prep list — quantities based on today's volume.	Break down wok station. Clean and season woks. Store day-old rice for tomorrow's khao pad. Drain noodle soak water and refrigerate noodles.	Full clean. Final fridge temp log 1-4°C . Refill butterfly pea tea (steep overnight for tomorrow). Prep Thai iced tea base for tomorrow AM.

6 Financial Forecast

Service	Covers	Avg Spend	Daily Revenue
Breakfast/Early Lunch (7am-11am)	36	\$30	\$1,080
Lunch (11:30am-2:30pm)	54	\$40	\$2,160
Daily Total			\$3,240
Monthly (26 days)			\$84,240

Cost Category	Monthly	%
Food & Beverage 22%	\$18,533	22.0%
Labour (HC+LC+ST+FOH×2)	\$17,200	20.4%
Rent + Utilities + Misc	\$5,600	6.6%
Total Costs	\$41,333	49.1%
NET PROFIT	\$42,907	50.9%

3-Month Ramp: Month 1 (55%) ~\$8,200 net · Month 2 (75%) ~\$21,000 · Month 3 (100%) ~\$42,907 · Break-even at ~\$2,700/day requires 90 covers across both sessions. The beverage mix (Thai teas, cocktails, beer) is critical — target 1.8 drinks per guest to hit these numbers.

7 Service Training Module

SCRIPT 1 — THE TEA OPENING

"Can I get you a Thai iced tea while you look at the menu? We brew it strong with the traditional Thai tea leaves — it's sweet, slightly spiced, orange. Or the butterfly pea flower tea — it's blue until you put lime in it and it turns purple. \$5.99 each."

Why it works: The butterfly pea tea colour change is the most reliably effective drink sell in Thai food. The chemistry demo converts almost every table that hears it.

SCRIPT 2 — THE SPICE CONVERSATION

"Before I take your order — how spicy do you like things? Thai spicy means bird's eye chilies, which are legitimately hot. Medium means 2-3. Thai means 5-7. I always ask because the gap between medium and Thai is significant."

Why it works: Proactive spice management prevents complaints, creates a collaborative dynamic, and demonstrates that you know your product. Guests who feel informed don't complain even if it's spicier than expected.

SCRIPT 3 — THE SOM TUM MORTAR

"The som tum is made in the mortar — we make each one fresh to order. 6 minutes. The heat level is completely adjustable. \$12.99 and it's probably the most flavourful \$13 you'll spend today."

Why it works: The mortar detail communicates authenticity immediately. "Made fresh to order" is both honest and a quality signal. "Most flavourful \$13 you'll spend today" is a confident, memorable line.

SCRIPT 4 — THE MASSAMAN STORY

"The massaman — CNN called it the best food in the world a few years back. It's a slow-braised beef curry, Southern Thai, Muslim-influenced, so it has warm spices — cloves, cinnamon, nutmeg — rather than just chili heat. It's not aggressively spicy. \$19.99 with jasmine rice."

Why it works: The CNN reference is a genuine, memorable fact. Explaining the Muslim Southern Thai influence adds cultural depth. "Not aggressively spicy" removes the barrier for spice-uncertain guests.

SCRIPT 5 — THE FRIED BANANA PRE-SELL

"One thing worth knowing — the fried banana with coconut ice cream is 6 minutes if you want it at the end. I'll put it on when I bring your mains so it times right. \$8.99. The batter has coconut and sesame in it — it's not like a funfair doughnut."

Why it works: Pre-ordering removes the "too full" barrier. The coconut-sesame batter detail distinguishes it from cheap fried desserts. Timing it with the mains is a genuine service act that guests appreciate.

Table Timing Guide

Time	Action
0:00	Welcome and seat. Butterfly pea tea or Thai iced tea pitch immediately (Script 1). Small bowl of prawn crackers to the table — free, \$0.15, signals hospitality, Thai restaurant standard.
1:30	Spice conversation (Script 2) — before they order anything. Drink order taken.
4:00	Full food order. Scripts 3, 4 as relevant. Fried banana pre-sell (Script 5). Note dietary requirements — fish sauce is in almost every dish (vegetarian adaptations require specific substitutions).
10:00	Entrées arrive. Brief introduction: "The satay peanut sauce — dip the cucumber relish too, not just the skewers." One tip per dish that improves the eating experience.
20:00	Mains arrive. Place condiment tray: fish sauce + chili flakes + sugar + white vinegar. Brief: "Season to your taste — these are how every Thai restaurant in Bangkok serves it." This is cultural education that guests remember and appreciate.
30:00	Dessert prompt — mango sticky rice, tub tim grob, sangkaya all instant. Fried banana 6 min (already fired if pre-sold). Thai iced tea refill offered.
45:00	Bill. "Come back on a weekend — we sometimes run regional Thai specials from the regions: Northern, Southern, Isaan." Creates return intent and communicates depth of knowledge.

8 Customer Retention System

The Four Pillars Principle: Every dish on this menu must deliver all four Thai flavours

simultaneously — salty, sweet, sour, spicy. When all four are present and balanced, the palate experiences a satisfaction that is unique to Thai cuisine and is literally addictive at a neurological level. This is why people return to Thai restaurants more frequently than almost any other cuisine category. Your retention strategy is built on this flavour addiction — ensure every dish is perfectly balanced, every time.

The Discovery Ladder: Most non-Thai guests start with pad thai (safest) and progress over visits to green curry → massaman → pad kra pao → khao man gai → som tum. Each step up the ladder deepens their connection to the cuisine. Staff should actively guide this progression: "You loved the green curry last time — have you tried the massaman? It's completely different." Track what regulars have tried and what they haven't.

5 VIP Micro-Moments

1. The Prawn Cracker Welcome. Prawn crackers with sweet chili sauce on the table within 60 seconds of seating. Cost: \$0.15. Impact: every Thai restaurant in Bangkok does this. It is the universal signal that the meal has started and the hospitality is genuine. Guests who haven't been to a proper Thai restaurant will not expect it — it immediately exceeds their baseline.

2. The Butterfly Pea Colour Change. When the tea arrives, say: "Squeeze the lime in — it turns purple." Watch them do it. Watch their face. This is a 5-second moment that generates a genuine emotional response. Take a photo of their reaction if they're comfortable with it. This is your social media content and your retention anchor in one moment.

3. The Mortar Presence. If you have counter or pass visibility, keep the mortar in sight. The sound of pounding, the visual of the cook working the mortar for each som tum order — this communicates authenticity more effectively than any menu description. Sound and sight together are the two most powerful restaurant marketing tools and they are completely free.

4. The Regional Story. When a regular has tried the core menu items, introduce them to regional Thai cuisine: "Have you had Isaan food? It's from Northeast Thailand — more sour, more fermented fish. Very different from Central Thai." This conversation establishes you as a knowledgeable guide to a deep subject, not just a pad thai dispensary. Depth creates loyalty.

5. The Spice Progression. For guests who always order mild: "Last time you had medium on the green curry — want to try medium-hot this time? I promise I won't push past your limit." This gentle progression toward authentic spice levels creates a shared journey. Guests who successfully eat spicier food than they thought they could feel accomplished and will return to push further. You are their guide.

BEST SOCIAL MEDIA POST — PAD KRA PAO

This is what 70 million Thais eat for lunch. [Hook]

Pad kra pao. Minced pork, holy basil, bird's eye chili, fish sauce. Wok must be screaming hot — the basil goes in for 10 seconds and comes straight out. The blistered fried egg on top, yolk still runny, breaks over the whole thing when you eat it. You mix it into the rice. That's it. That's the dish. [Story]
\$15.99. Open until 3pm. [CTA]